▶ **RAMANAN LAXMINARAYAN** *Founder & Director, One Health Trust*

THE LURKING DANGER



"CLIMATE CHANGE IS A HUGE DRIVER OF DISEASE RISK, LIKE THE MELTING OF THE ARCTIC PERMAFROST. THE SIBERIAN PERMAFROST CONTAINS A LOT OF VIRUSES AND BACTERIA THAT WERE BURIED THERE WELL BEFORE HUMANS EVER CAME ON THE PLANET"

"Antibiotics are hugely misused across South Asia...easily available without a prescription. As a result, bacteria have become resistant to antibiotics"

Even though the world seems to have moved on from the Covid-19 pandemic, the World Health Organization (WHO) continues to warn of an upcoming disease outbreak, most likely to be caused by an unknown pathogen, simply labelled 'Disease X'. One of the reasons for this forecast is how viruses have been evolving. In the past two decades alone, coronaviruses, which once caused only common cold, have led to three major outbreaks—SARS, MERS and COVID-19. There are also a number of drug-resistant pathogens, especially bacteria, which are cropping up across the world.

While there is no real evidence for what could cause the next pandemic, some experts feel it is likely to be a virus of animal origin. "The reason zoonotic viruses are problematic," said economist-epidemiologist Ramanan Laxminarayan at the India Today Conclave, "is because we have no experience with them from an immune perspective; our bodies have never seen them.... This is just, you know, evolution at work." Disease X could also be a fungal germ. If that's the case, "it could happen from right here", he said, and that's "problematic because there are no vaccines. And we have very, very few drugs to treat those with".

In order to prepare for Disease X, India needs to invest in disease surveillance, healthcare facilities, better vaccination coverage and sanitation practices. "The major preparation will have to be in cooperating with other countries," said Laxminarayan, "like through the pandemic accord, which is now being discussed at the WHO." It will ensure, he added, that when the disease occurs, wherever it is, everyone gets to know about it. "We are in it together." ■

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- **Climate change, antibiotic misuse, global travel and overconsumption of animals/ poultry are all setting the scene for another global pandemic, most likely to be caused by an unknown pathogen simply labelled Disease X**
- **Global cooperation for drugs, vaccines and awareness is critical to manage another Covid-19-like pandemic**

Photographs by **BANDEEP SINGH**